



Pillar of support: Kartik with his father, Manoj Sharma. The attention Kartik received in his early days was more important than he could have known. PICS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Realising there were few quality academies nearby, Manoj took a four-year-old Kartik to the academy of Lokendra Singh Chahar, father of India international Deepak Chahar, in Agra, about 56 kilometres away. "Even Lokendra sir wasn't convinced whether I would be able to play with senior boys. I was the youngest, so he worried the ball might hit me. But after watching me bat, he took me along," Kartik says, smiling.

Chahar remembers those days well. Initially hesitant, the seasoned coach soon realised the youngster had something special. "His speciality was that he could hit sixes at will. He was fearless, which was rare at that age," Chahar says.

Once he was convinced of Kartik's potential, Chahar enrolled him at the academy. "Despite financial challenges, my father sent me to Agra, where we rented a house. I trained under Lokendra sir through the week, returned to Bharatpur for a few days, and attended school. That's how I balanced cricket and

studies," says Kartik, who studied till Class 12 and now hopes to complete his graduation.

This routine continued for more than a decade. "I still visit sir's academy now and then and train there," he says. "For a young cricketer, it's easy to get carried away by early success or weighed down by failure. Lokendra sir took care of my mental conditioning too." Kartik recalls how his coach would spend an hour after training every day, working on mindset. "He told me to aim big and focus on fulfilling those dreams. That has helped me over the years."

It came at a cost. Manoj sold a plot of land and farmland in Bahnera village, while Radha sold her jewellery to support their son's training. Through harsh winters and unforgiving summers, Manoj accompanied Kartik to tournaments across the country.

Kartik recalls one such event when they went hungry. "It was during an invitational tournament in Gwalior," he says. Manoj had expected the competition to end in a couple of days, but Kartik's performances carried the team to the title. On the eve of the final, father and son had no money left for food. "It's because of my parents'

